

STATE OF OKLAHOMA

2nd Session of the 60th Legislature (2026)

HOUSE BILL 3241

By: Hasenbeck

AS INTRODUCED

An Act relating to schools; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.229-6, which relates to the program of character education; naming the Teaching Honesty, Respect, Integrity, Virtue, and Excellence (THRIVE) Act; requiring the State Department of Education to develop a character traits and personal skills education curriculum; listing exclusive traits and values to be included; providing completion date; clarifying that the program is available to public schools and charter schools; prohibiting use of additional traits and values; requiring the board of education of each school district to develop a process for program participation and opting out; requiring the Department to report participation and noncompliance by school district; allowing the Department and schools to accept certain funds; requiring schools to provide school premises for certain program participation; providing purpose; reconciling conflicts; providing an effective date; and declaring an emergency.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.229-6, is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.229-6. A. This act shall be known and may be cited as the Teaching Honesty, Respect, Integrity, Virtue, and Excellence (THRIVE) Act. ~~The board of education of every school~~

~~district in this state may~~ State Department of Education shall
develop and implement a comprehensive program ~~for~~ of positive
~~character education in any single grade or combination of grades,~~
traits and personal skill education as part of the subject matter
standards adopted by the Department for grades prekindergarten
through twelfth pursuant to Sections 11-103.6 and 11-103.7 of this
title. The positive character traits and personal skills education
program shall focus on development of character traits in students.
The program of character education ~~may~~ shall include, ~~but shall not~~
~~be limited to,~~ the voluntary reciting of the Pledge of Allegiance to
the flag of the United States of America, and otherwise shall
consist exclusively of instruction in the value of finishing high
school, working full time, getting married before having children,
and instruction in all of, and only, the following character traits
and fundamental values deeply rooted in the history and tradition of
the United States:

1. Trustworthiness, including honesty, reliability,
punctuality, and loyalty;

2. Responsibility, including hard work, accountability,
diligence, good judgment, perseverance, and self-control;

3. Care for family, including parents, siblings, and future
spouses and children;

4. Kindness and generosity toward others;

5. Respect and care for human life;

1 6. Respect for parental authority;

2 7. Respect for parents' obligations to children;

3 8. Respect for the property of other people;

4 9. Respect for legitimate authority and law;

5 10. Respect for patriotism, service to the community, and
6 concern for the common good;

7 11. Respect for religious faith, morality, wisdom, and
8 knowledge;

9 12. Respect for lifelong marriage, sexual fidelity within
10 marriage, and sexual abstinence outside of marriage;

11 13. Gratitude;

12 14. Charity; and

13 15. Courage.

14 B. ~~The~~ 1. Not later than the beginning of the 2026-2027 school
15 year, the State Department of Education shall develop and make
16 available to all public school districts and charter schools through
17 an Internet website, the following:

18 ~~1. Technical~~

19 a. technical assistance upon request of a public school
20 district, ~~or~~ or charter school,

21 ~~2. A~~

22 b. a list of approved ~~research-based~~ positive character
23 traits and personal skills education programs,
24 curricula, and materials, in compliance with the

requirements of this section, which may be used by
public school districts, and charter schools,

3. A

c. a positive character traits and personal skills
education honor roll that will recognize public school
districts and charter schools that have successfully
implemented a comprehensive school-district-wide
program of positive character traits and personal
skills education and will highlight the positive
impacts the program has had on each public school or,
school district, or charter school, and

4. A

d. a positive character traits and personal skills
education reading list of books that may include, but
is not limited to, books that illustrate models of
good character one or more of the character traits and
personal skills set forth in subsection A of this
section, and books that relate to the development of
good such positive character traits and personal
skills that may be used by schools in a character
education program.

2. The State Department of Education shall not include any
programs, curricula, or materials in the approved list required in
subparagraph b of paragraph 1 of this subsection that contradict or

undermine respect for the character traits and personal skills
required to be taught pursuant to this section. The Department's
approval of programs, curricula, or materials pursuant to this
section is ministerial only and not discretionary. Districts and
schools may only satisfy the requirements of this section by
adopting programs, curricula, or materials from the Department's
approved list as provided in this section.

~~C. Subject to the availability of funding, the State Board of~~
~~Education may award grants to ten school districts for the~~
~~establishment of pilot projects which align character education with~~
~~the state curriculum in reading, mathematics, science or social~~
~~studies and demonstrate how character education teaches life skills~~
~~that lead to career readiness. The amount of each grant shall be~~
~~One Thousand Dollars (\$1,000.00). The projects shall be innovative~~
~~programs that will serve as models for other school districts.~~
~~Funding may cover the cost of purchasing curriculum, materials, or~~
~~training teachers. The Board shall determine pilot project criteria~~
~~and establish a process for the consideration of proposals. The~~
~~proposals for pilot projects shall be considered on a statewide~~
~~competitive basis. The Board shall promulgate rules for the~~
~~operation of the projects~~ The board of education of each school
district shall adopt a process to issue a public notice of the
adoption of the success sequence and character education curriculum
required hereunder, to make course materials available for public

1 inspection, and to provide parents and legal guardians a means to
2 opt their child out of participation in the courses. Participation
3 in the success sequence and character education courses of
4 instruction required hereunder may be terminated by the student's
5 parent or legal guardian at any time upon written notice to the
6 board. No student whose parent or legal guardian elects to opt out
7 shall be required to participate in the success sequence and
8 character education courses of instruction established under this
9 section.

10 D. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, no later than
11 sixty (60) days following the beginning of each school year, the
12 State Department of Education shall provide to the Governor,
13 Lieutenant Governor, Speaker of the Oklahoma House of
14 Representatives, President Pro Tempore of the Oklahoma State Senate
15 and chairpersons of the committees of the Senate and House of
16 Representatives that primarily deal with education, a report
17 stating, as of the reporting date, the total number of public school
18 districts, the number and names of schools and districts that have
19 adopted success sequence and character education courses in
20 compliance with the requirements of this section, the number and
21 names of districts not in compliance, reasons given by noncompliant
22 districts for their noncompliance, and actions taken by the State
23 Department of Education to bring noncompliant schools and districts
24

1 into compliance. The report shall be made available to the public
2 in a clearly accessible manner on the Department's website.

3 E. The State Department of Education, districts, and schools
4 may accept federal or private funds for the purpose of assisting
5 with implementation of success sequence and character education
6 courses in compliance with the requirements of this act.

7 F. 1. Not later than the beginning of the 2026-2027 school
8 year, the board of education of each school district shall adopt a
9 policy to make the school premises available for voluntary
10 participation by students, with consent of the students' parent or
11 legal guardian, in after-school instruction programs provided by
12 third parties that instruct pupils in the philosophical, historical,
13 traditional, or religious justifications for the success sequence
14 and character education curriculum established under subsection A of
15 this section. The State Department of Education shall make a list
16 of approved after-school programs available to districts, schools,
17 and parents and shall adopt a process, in cooperation with the
18 third-party providers, to obtain the consent of the student and the
19 student's parent or legal guardian for the student's participation.
20 Consent for a student's participation in the program may be revoked
21 at any time by the student, parent, or legal guardian upon written
22 notice to the school or school board.

23 2. The purpose of the after-school instruction program is to
24 provide philosophical, historical, traditional, or religious

1 justifications for the success sequence and character traits set
2 forth in subsection A of this section. No after-school instruction
3 program that is inconsistent with said purpose or subject matter
4 shall be approved. Subject to the requirement of purpose and
5 subject matter consistency, a school board shall not deny approval
6 to any afterschool program based on its viewpoint, or on the grounds
7 that the program contains expression protected by the First
8 Amendment of the United States Constitution, or Section 2 of Article
9 I or Section 22 of Article II of the Oklahoma Constitution.

10 G. In the event of a conflict between the requirements of this
11 section and any other Oklahoma statute, administrative code,
12 regulation, guidance or policy, the requirements of this section
13 shall control.

14 SECTION 2. This act shall become effective July 1, 2026.

15 SECTION 3. It being immediately necessary for the preservation
16 of the public peace, health or safety, an emergency is hereby
17 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and
18 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

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